

THE INSOMNIA COOKIES STORY

A BRAND BUILT AROUND JUST A COOKIE

One student, one dorm room, \$150. Sources: Wikipedia, CNBC, Fortune, HuffPost, How I Built This (NPR), Daily Pennsylvanian.

Somewhere, someone once looked at a bakery counter and asked a simple question: why is there no real brand built entirely around the cookie? Turns out, someone already answered it. Twenty years ago, a college student asked exactly that -- and built a company now worth hundreds of millions of dollars, one warm cookie at a time.

THE IDEA

University of Pennsylvania.
2003.

Fact	Detail
Founder	Seth Berkowitz, an economics major at Penn's Wharton School.
The spark	Living in a college house with eight roommates, tired of the same late-night pizza orders, craving something sweet instead -- with zero late-night dessert delivery options anywhere nearby.
Starting capital	About \$150 spent on baking supplies.
The first move	Baked the first batch himself and handed out free samples on Penn's Locust Walk. Instant hit -- friends said they'd pay if he delivered.
The product	Just cookies. Delivered warm, late at night, 9pm to 2am -- built entirely around when people actually wanted them.

A cookie. Something sitting on every bakery counter in the world. Nobody had built a brand purely around it.

THE MOMENT IT TOOK OFF

One newspaper story
changed everything

Milestone	Detail
The breakthrough	The campus newspaper, The Daily Pennsylvanian, ran a front-page feature on the dorm-room cookie delivery business.
The jump	Orders went from 3 a night to 80 a night, almost overnight.
What happened next	He hired help, found a bigger kitchen, and within a couple of years secured FDA approval, opened his first retail shop, and brought in angel investors -- before he had even graduated.
First storefront	Opened in Syracuse, New York -- the first step from a dorm-room delivery service to a real retail chain.

THE SCALE

From one dorm room to a
national brand

Milestone	Detail
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2018	Krispy Kreme -- yes, the doughnut company -- acquired a majority stake in Insomnia Cookies.
Locations today	265+ stores per Wikipedia, with more recent reporting citing 350+ locations across the US, Canada, and England.
Volume	Over 20 million cookies sold every single quarter.
Where they are	Major cities, suburbs, transportation hubs, stadiums -- far beyond the college campuses where it started.
Valuation	Reported at roughly \$350 million.
Ownership today	Backed by Krispy Kreme alongside private equity firms Verlinvest and Mistral Equity Partners.

The Takeaway

A cookie. Not a new invention. Not a secret recipe nobody else could copy. Something sitting on a counter in front of millions of people, every single day, for decades. One person looked at it and simply asked why nobody had built a real brand around it -- and then did. The biggest opportunities are not always hidden. Sometimes they are sitting in plain sight, waiting for someone to actually build around them.

Based on research and personal experience. Please do your own research as well.

Research by @iamsatyavyas | Sources: Wikipedia, CNBC, Fortune, HuffPost, How I Built This (NPR), Daily Pennsylvanian | July 2026